

3.2.4 2D Islam

Students are required to study those aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Islam specified below and the different ways in which these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Islam
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought). However students are expected to recognise and understand the following technical terms: Tawhid, Barzakh, Al-Qadr, Jihad.

Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Qur'an: its nature and authority; Muslim beliefs about the revelation and compilation of the Qur'an; the importance of the Arabic text and how this is reflected in the treatment and use of the Qur'an in worship and in everyday life; translation as interpretation and the importance of trustworthy interpretation of the Qur'an.
- The Prophet: the status of Muhammad as Khatam an-Nabiyyin (seal of the Prophets) and his significance for Muslims today; different views about the nature and value of hadiths as sources of knowledge of the sayings and actions of Muhammad.
- Imams: the authority of the Imams in Shi'a Islam.

God

- Tawhid: the Oneness of God; God as transcendent and indescribable, the omnipotent creator and controller of all things; teaching about God in the Throne verse: 2:255.
- Personal aspects of God: The significance of 'The Merciful' and 'The Compassionate' as Names of God; different Muslim views about how anthropomorphic descriptions of God in the

Qur'an should be interpreted. Ashari, Hanbali and Mutazili views, with particular reference to the hand of God and the face of God.

- Aspects of the Sufi concept of God: God as incomparable and unknowable in Himself ; Creation as emanation and God as immanent; the soul as one with God; Sufi understandings of the teaching about God in the verse of Light: 24:35.

Self, death and afterlife

- Muslim views about the purpose of life as being to worship God and a moral test; the concept of worship and consideration of the view that, for Muslims, this life is only important as a preparation for the life to come.
- Al-Qadr: different understandings of the relationship between divine control, human freedom and responsibility. Mutazili and Ashari perspectives and the Shi'a concept of Bada.
- Akhirah (afterlife): the concept of soul; beliefs about Barzakh, judgement heaven and hell including different understandings of resurrection and of the descriptions of heaven and hell in the Qur'an including 47:15.

Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in Islam including reference to the duty of obedience to God and the Prophet and to the greater jihad; the role of personal freedom and judgement in the Shari'ah law, with reference to the five-fold classification of actions.
- Sanctity of life: the concept of the sanctity of life and its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child; lesser jihad as a duty of the Ummah and how it applied to warfare at the time of the Prophet; debates about its application today, including to the use of weapons of mass destruction and terrorism.
- Stewardship: the role of the Ummah as Khalifah (stewards) and their responsibilities towards the environment and to animal life; how changing understandings of the impact of human activities on the world change Muslim understandings of their responsibilities.

Expressions of religious identity

- The concept of Muslim: the similarities and differences between Shi'a and Sunni views about what it means to be a Muslim.
- The Pillars of Islam: the concept of pillar and purpose of the five pillars of Islam; Salah: differences in Sunni and Shi'a practices; the importance of the outward actions of prayer and the underlying intentions and state of mind; the importance of daily and Jummah prayers; Hajj: developments in the practice of Hajj in the 20th century and the significance and importance of Hajj today.
- The mosque: the changing role of the mosque in the community, with particular reference to the history and developing work of the London Central Mosque.